

Polarization

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The issue of polarization most clearly documents that Political Communication is a polyphonic field in which different disciplines fruitfully engage based on a broad range of questions and method(ological) approaches. The phenomenon itself is multilayered, and the definitions and concepts used in different lines of research need to be considered in order to map the field of study (see below). Empirically, polarization is usually studied in national contexts. An especially rich and diverse body of literature has developed with a focus on the United States, but case studies have also covered countries, for example, in Africa, Europe, Latin America, and South Asia (e.g., Carothers and O'Donohue 2019). Furthermore, comparative analyses have determined significant cross-nationally relevant patterns, conflict dynamics, and categories of actors (e.g. McCoy et al. 2018). The interest in and the relevance of the study of polarization have continuously grown, especially as a range of phenomena with detrimental effects even in established democracies have been related to severe polarization. These include the erosion of social cohesion and trust; the decline of functional governmental capacities, cross-party cooperation, and compromises; and the undermining of fundamental principles and institutions that legitimize and facilitate liberal-democratic government (e.g. McCoy et al. 2018). At the same time, positive effects of increased polarization—for example the energizing of (potential) voters or the establishment of programmatic and cohesive parties offering clear choices and a higher level of representation—have been outlined (e.g., Abramowitz 2010). In dealing with polarization, conceptual clarity is thus imperative. The next section will thus present the different types of polarization that have been conceptualized and will highlight major findings and debates in the respective literatures. As the destructive potential described above predominantly relates to *affective* polarization, section 3 will outline major strands of research into its sources and conducive conditions, in particular as they relate to political and media communication.

Types of polarization

Initially, the study of polarization focused on *ideological* or *issue-based polarization* (in the United States). In their essence, these concepts refer to the consistency or hardening of political attitudes, beliefs, and preferences within parties. This contributes to a growing ideological distance between parties as extant differences regarding a range of issues increasingly confluence around each of the two poles of the ideological spectrum (e.g., McCarty et al. 2008). Important distinctions between the mass level and the elite level of society, however, raised the question of whether rising polarization was limited to policy-makers and party representatives and activists (e.g., Fiorina 2010; Hacker and Pierson 2005) or whether the center was 'disappearing' throughout society based on a cyclical dynamic of increasing polarization between the political elite and members of the mass public (e.g., Abramowitz 2010). These trends were assessed through a variety of methods including systematic reviews of polling data or spatial models of representatives' voting records. As such, a certain degree of polarization that entails opportunities for a greater variety of attitudes and demands to be represented can be expected in diverse democracies and can even be considered beneficial.

During the past decades, however, a distinct type of polarization has come into focus that drives the more 'pernicious consequences' for democratic societies and governance outlined above (e.g. McCoy et al. 2018: 17): *Affective* polarization relies on and activates (e.g., religious, racial, or cultural components of) social identities. These allow the definition of meaningful group affiliations and a corresponding dislike of 'untrustworthy' out-groups (Iyengar et al. 2012; McCoy et al. 2018). While ideological and affective polarization have been established as two analytically separate concepts, there continues to be debate around their specific relationship. Some scholars argue that ideological distance strongly shapes feelings toward political opponents, thereby enhancing affective polarization (Webster and Abramowitz 2017). Others maintain that the correlation is more complex (Reiljan 2020) or that the importance of ideology should not be overstated. Here, the decline in cross-cutting identities as well as partisan elites' strategic political rhetoric and messaging that entrenches intra-group

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hostility are the main drivers of affective polarization (Lelkes 2018). As identity-based factors are organized around partisan affiliations, the relevance of these affiliations is greatly enhanced (Mason 2018). This can intensify an 'us-versus-them' mentality to a point where the strength of partisanship trumps the commitment to core democratic principles (Graham and Svobik 2020).

Mechanisms driving polarization and the role of political communication

With regard to the mechanisms underlying rising (affective) polarization among political elites and the broader public, a focus on political communication is thus important. A strategic approach for electoral gain is assumed in most concepts. Political actors may thus seek to exploit extant (ideological) rifts through prominent attacks on the out-group that trigger affective reactions. As the public is increasingly and consistently exposed to such political rhetoric, partisans' biased views of their opponents will be confirmed and reinforced (Iyengar et al. 2012).

Other scholars have suggested that cue-taking might go even further. Two related mechanisms were tested by Kingzette et al (2021) to explain how affective polarization can even affect support for democratic norms in the electorate: First, party elites with autocratic inclinations in highly polarized contexts may publicly contest democratic norms that constrain their actions while the opposing party will express continued support for upholding them. This presents voters with distinct partisan cues that politicize constitutional foundations of checks and balances. Second, affective polarization may promote partisan biases against the out-group that lead increasingly committed partisans from both sides to oppose norms that mandate political tolerance and the fair treatment of contrasting positions. The results suggest that elite cue-taking rather than general partisan biases explain the connection between affective polarization and (diminished) support for democratic norms (Kingzette et al. 2021).

Importantly, polarization research on the United States suggests an important asymmetry in the sense that the (conservative) Republican Party has been the main driver of this development (e.g., Hacker and Pierson 2005; McCarty 2019). Similar asymmetric

trends have also been identified in other democracies such as Poland (Fomina 2019).

The multifaceted dynamics of affective polarization ...

A key interest of polarization scholarship has been to determine and analyze the causes, sources, and conducive conditions of—in particular affective—polarization. A first strand of literature studies how the electoral and institutional architecture of countries may explain cross-national variations. The model of consensus democracy, for instance, is probed for elements that attenuate polarization. In general terms, its *horizontal* and *vertical* 'institutional protection of multiple cleavages and identities in society obstructs the creation of one overarching axis of polarization'¹ in both ideological and affective forms (Bernaerts et al. 2023: 158). Affective polarization (of varying intensity) nevertheless also exists in European systems (Reiljan 2020). Here, policy issues as well as *horizontal* institutional features incentivize a multi-party system, and government coalitions have been found to shape multiparty affective relations in very particular ways. For example, out-party antipathy grows with ideological distance (Harteveld 2021) and with elite disagreement on cultural rather than economic issues (Gidron et al. 2023). At the same time, coalition partners in government grant each other an 'affective bonus' that does not rely on the closeness of their policy or ideological stances (Gidron et al. 2023). Furthermore, the *vertical* power-sharing arrangement of federalism is ascribed a particularly strong polarization-moderating potential (Bernaerts et al. 2023: 162–163). Yet, as Pierson and Schickler (2020) demonstrate, this (causal) relationship is more complex and not static or uni-directional: in the US case, initial polarization contributed to changes in meso-institutions, such as interest groups, state parties, and the media, through which, over time, (nationalized) polarization intensified and became self-reinforcing as previously cross-cutting cleavages were increasingly stacked. This helped to coalesce originally plural and cross-cutting social (ideological, racial, religious, geographic, etc.) ties around a partisan 'mega identity' (Mason 2018: 14) that fosters affective partisan biases and hostility against the out-group.

... in mediated communication contexts

A second strand of research more closely zooms in on the multi-faceted role of the media in the process of growing (affective) polarization. The transformation into a high-choice online and offline media environment has multiplied the opportunities for selective exposure to attitude-congruent contents. Group homogeneity in distinct pockets of the segmented information and communication space has thereby had important polarizing effects (e.g. Stroud 2011; Sunstein 2018). The United States is a particularly noteworthy case in this regard, also because polarization is asymmetric in several regards: a rather self-referential (radical) right-wing media ecosystem has developed that ‘differs categorically from the rest of the media environment’ and actively promotes distrust of the latter (Benkler et al. 2018: 13; Sobieraj and Berry 2011: 30). This is reflected on the ground in self-identified Republicans’ growing alienation from most of the established news sources (Jurkowitz et al. 2020). Importantly, the fragmentation and narrow-casting of the media environment risks adding an epistemic dimension to polarization through the ‘balkanization’ of knowledge (Sunstein 2018: 66) and the (sometimes deliberate) promotion of out-right disinformation and disorientation. This undermines established epistemic authorities including the professional press, governmental agencies, and the scientific community and, in effect, impairs fact-based communication and governing as well as social integration and trust (Benkler et al. 2018; Tucker et al. 2018). In Political Communication, one important focus has been on (the effects of) elite rhetoric and modes of delivery in mediated contexts. According to this research, media systems oriented toward infotainment and sensationalism not only give heightened attention to campaigns characterized by emotional appeals (especially fear) but also to those marked by negativity (Maier and Nai 2020) which, in turn, has been shown to at least temporarily reinforce animosity and distrust toward the leaders as well as the rank-and-file of the opposition (Iyengar et al. 2012). Increasingly, political elites seem to drive affective polarization also through uncivil modes of delivery that can be escalated into ‘outrage tactics’ seeking ‘to provoke visceral responses (e.g., anger, righteousness,

fear, moral indignation) from the audience through the use of overgeneralizations, sensationalism, misleading or patently inaccurate information, ad hominem attacks, and partial truths about opponents’ (Sobieraj and Berry 2011: 20; Mason 2018, chapter 6). Different forms of elite political incivility thereby induce affective reactions (in particular anger) that can provoke more combative partisanship (Gervais 2019) and the use of incivility by partisans themselves (Rega and Marchetti 2021). Lastly, potential meta effects of the relationship between media reporting and polarization have received some (yet not sufficient) attention: Levendusky and Malhotra (2016), for instance, show that depictions in the media of a widespread polarization across issues that is accompanied by incivility and out-group animosity moderates ideological polarization, but, notably, reinforces affective polarization in partisans.

A plea for a stronger Political Communication focus on affective polarization and populism

Throughout these different approaches to affective polarization, the phenomenon of contemporary populism is increasingly present—sometimes only implicitly so, when the construction of mutually exclusive social identities, the debasing of out-groups, or the delegitimization of compromises, institutions, epistemic authorities, or oppositional views are documented in (the effects of) elite rhetoric. Other studies more explicitly underline its relevance, for instance, as they identify an extraordinary level of affective polarization between populist and non-populist partisans they refer to as a ‘populist radical right exceptionalism’ (Harteveld 2021; Gidron et al. 2023). Even more, the role of populist discourses and logic as drivers of a supremely affective ‘pernicious’ polarization (McCoy et al. 2018) has gained attention (Roberts 2022). As populists have an ‘elective affinity’ with particular media formats, modes of articulation and (‘post-truth’-)messaging (Gerbaudo 2018; Waisbord 2018) that have been flagged as highly relevant to growing affective polarization above, Political Communication stands out as a field where these interrelations can fruitfully be further explored.

Note

1. Ideal-typically, Bernaerts et al. (2023) refer to proportional electoral systems, oversized coalitions, and federalism.

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